Chapter 13

An Unforgettable Escape: The Road to Freedom

KIRAN'S DAUGHTER, SAINA, HAD CLEARED HER STD X FROM THE Convent of Jesus and Mary in New Delhi. Due to Kiran's transfer to Mizoram, she had to change her school. She did her Stds XI and XII, the most important years of schooling, from a Central school (the Kendriya Vidyalaya) in Aizawl. This effectively debarred her from taking her pre-medical examination from Delhi, which required a mandatory condition to be fulfilled that the concerned student should have done Stds XI and XII from Delhi itself. This debarment left her with the option of appearing only in the all-India examinations. Because of the comparable differences in the educational facilities between Delhi and Mizoram, this option again required that she be in Delhi, which of course was not possible, given the exigencies of her mother's service conditions. In the course of a conversation with her friends at school, Saina learnt that as she was studying in Aizawl she could compete for the medical seats allotted by the Central Government to Mizoram. The ranking done on the merit list of the Std XII examinations would be the deciding criterion, and she plunged herself into studies despite the lack of sufficient guidance at the school at Aizawl.

The school was deficient in teachers. She cleared the board examinations admirably well, securing 89 per cent marks, the highest among the non-Mizo students. Interestingly, the two Mizo girls above her in the merit list had done their earlier schooling in Madras (now known as Chennai). However, to apply for the medical seat quota, Saina had to attach her domicile certificate. Kiran requested the district collector for this certificate but was told in no uncertain terms that she would not be given one. She then explained to one of her officers that all she wanted from the DC was a certificate stating that Saina had been domiciled in Aizawl for the past two years. The officer asked her to speak to the DC on the telephone and explain the situation to him. The DC agreed to consider the matter and later this same officer collected the certificate of residence. This certificate was dispatched along with the application and mark sheet to the relevant authorities who asked Saina to appear for an interview. At the interview she was asked for her choice of medical college location and she left it to the board to decide.

For a long time, no list was announced and nothing was made public. Everyone kept guessing about the government's intention. As regards seats for other courses, the lists of candidates, selected on merit, were duly announced, but not those of the medical course. Such an announcement, apparently, was the prerogative of the chief minister.

An interesting event that took place during this period of waiting was that the non-Mizo doctors' lobby in Mizoram, which was always close to the powers that be, started pressing for the selection of non-Mizo students for the reserved quota not on the basis of merit but on that of the longer period of domicile. Politics was apparently at work, dividing the Mizo and the non-Mizo communities, small